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Prompt Engineering Cheat Sheet

Techniques for getting the best results from LLMs.

CORE PRINCIPLES

Be specific & unambiguous
Provide context & background
State the desired output format
Give examples when possible
Iterate & refine prompts
Break complex tasks into steps
Specify audience & tone

ROLE PROMPTING

"You are an expert [role]..."
"Act as a senior [profession]..."
"As a [persona], explain..."

"You are a code reviewer..."
"Respond as a teacher to a novic

CHAIN OF THOUGHT

"Think step by step..."
"Let's work through this..."
"First..., then..., finally..."
"Show your reasoning."
"Explain each step before..."

"Before answering, consider..."

FEW-SHOT EXAMPLES

Input: [example1]
Output: [result1]
Input: [example2]
Output: [result2]
Input: [your actual input]
Output:

OUTPUT FORMATTING

"Respond in JSON format."
"Use a markdown table."
"List exactly 5 bullet points."
"Keep response under 100 words."
"Format as: Title, Body, Tags"
"Return only the code, no prose."
"Use headers for each section."

ZERO-SHOT TECHNIQUES

"Without examples, just..."
"Classify the following as..."
"Summarise in one sentence:"
"Translate to formal English:"
"Extract all names from:"
"Rate sentiment as +/-/neutral:"
"Convert to bullet points:"

TEMPERATURE & STYLE

"Be concise and direct."
"Be creative and expansive."
"Use simple language."
"Use technical terminology."
"Avoid hedging language."

CONTEXT STUFFING

"Given this data: [data]..."
"Based on this document: ..."
"The user's goal is [goal]..."
"Constraints: [list limits]"
"Previous steps: [history]"
"Audience: [who will read this]"

SELF-CONSISTENCY

"Generate 3 different answers."
"What are pros AND cons?"
"Argue both sides of..."
"Check your answer for errors."
"Is there a simpler approach?"
"What assumptions did you make
"What could go wrong here?"

TASK DECOMPOSITION

"Break this into subtasks:"
"What are the steps to..."
"First do X, then do Y, then Z"
"Solve each part separately."

"Complete step 1 only for now."
"Now continue to step 2..."

NEGATIVE PROMPTING

"Do NOT include..."
"Avoid using the word..."
"Do not repeat yourself."
"Do not include caveats."
"Don't explain, just output."
"Skip the introduction."
"No bullet points · prose only."

SYSTEM PROMPTS (API)

system: 'You are a [role]...'

system: 'Always respond in JSON
system: 'Reply only in French'
system: 'Never discuss [topic]'